

How to Price a Made-to-Measure Garment

The full calculation: materials, hours, costs, profit and deposit.

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Why pricing by eye costs you money

A made-to-measure corset holds far more work than the photo shows.

The price of a made-to-measure garment doesn't come from looking at what others charge. It comes from adding up what you spend, the hours you work and what you want to earn. This guide takes you through that sum step by step, and the calculator does it for you.

When you price by eye, three things happen:

- You forget things you did pay for: the busk, the boning, the tape, the eyelets, the thread, the interfacing, the toile fabric.
- You don't count the hours that aren't sewing: taking measurements, the fitting, answering messages, going out for materials.
- You leave no margin for mistakes: a fabric that gets ruined, an extra fitting, an adjustment that takes twice as long.

The rule of this guide

First you work out what it costs you. Then you decide how much you want to earn. A price never starts with “how much will they pay me?”.

PART 2

Materials

Everything that goes into the garment, however small.

Write down every material with what you paid and the share you use. If you bought 3 meters of tape and use 1, you count a third of the price.

MATERIAL	CORSET	BRA / BRALETTE	BODYSUIT	BRIEFS
Outer fabric	✓	✓	✓	✓
Lining / inner fabric	✓	✓	depends on style	depends on style
Coutil or firm fabric	✓	—	—	—
Boning (steel or plastic)	✓	sometimes	sometimes	—
Busk or fastening	✓	—	—	—
Eyelets / grommets and lacing	✓	—	—	—
Underwires and channelling	—	✓ if wired	depends on style	—
Elastic (strip, picot, straps)	—	✓	✓	✓
Hooks, sliders and rings	—	✓	✓	—
Lace, tulle, embroidery	depends on design	depends on design	depends on design	depends on design
Thread, interfacing, bias binding	✓	✓	✓	✓
Toile fabric (fitting)	✓	✓	✓	—
Label, bag or gift box	✓	✓	✓	✓

Add 10% for the unexpected

Cuts that go wrong, thread that runs out, a bone that needs replacing. The calculator adds it for you (you can change it).

PART 3

Your hours

The sewing hours and the ones nobody sees.

Time yourself over two or three garments with a stopwatch, or by writing down when you start and finish. The first few times you'll be slower; with practice it comes down.

STAGE	WHAT IT INCLUDES
Client care	Messages, consultation, quote, taking measurements
Pattern	Printing, assembling, grading to the client's measurements
Toile	Cutting and sewing the test fabric
Fittings	Each fitting with the client and the corrections
Cutting and sewing	The final garment
Finishing	Boning, eyelets, binding, pressing
Delivery	Packaging, posting or handover

What is your hour worth?

Choose an hourly rate that feels fair for skilled work, and review it from time to time. One way to think about it: how much you want to earn in a month doing this, divided by the real hours you can give it. That number is yours; the calculator just uses it.

Workshop costs

What you use even though it doesn't go into the garment.

Electricity for the machine and iron, needles, cutter blades, paper and pattern printing, machine servicing, internet. A simple approach: add up what you spend on those things in a month and divide by the garments you make that month. That's your "fixed cost per garment".

PART 5

The full calculation

This is how the calculator works it out.

- 1 **Materials** + 10% for the unexpected.
- 2 **Hours** × your hourly rate.
- 3 **Fixed cost** per garment.
- 4 That's your **cost**: the minimum so you don't lose money.
- 5 **Profit**: a percentage on top of the cost (you choose it).
- 6 **Final price** = cost + profit, rounded up.
- 7 **Deposit**: a percentage of the final price that covers at least the materials.

An example to understand the sum

The figures in this example are placeholders to show the calculation; replace them with yours.

ITEM	SUM	RESULT
Materials	$A + 10\%$	$A \times 1.10$
Hours	$12 \text{ h} \times R$	$12 \times R$
Fixed cost	F	F
Cost	materials + hours + fixed cost	C
30% profit	$C \times 0.30$	$C \times 0.30$
Price	$C + \text{profit}$	$C \times 1.30$
50% deposit	$\text{price} \times 0.50$	—

Sets

If you sell a set (for example corset + briefs), add up the cost of each piece and work out the profit on the total. Don't discount your hours: if you want to reward the set, give a small extra (a garter, a pretty bag), not your work.

PART 6

The deposit and the commission rules

So nobody leaves you with a half-made garment.

- Ask for a deposit before you buy materials. Between 30% and 50% is most common; it should cover at least what you'll spend on materials.
- Put in writing what the price includes: how many fittings, timeline, postage or collection.
- Design changes after the fabric is cut are quoted separately.
- The garment is handed over once the balance is paid.

All of this is already set out in the “Order Form + Commission Terms”.

PART 7

When to review your prices

A price isn't forever.

Review your prices when...

- ☐ The price of your materials has changed.
- ☐ You're faster than before: your hour is worth the same, but you earn more per garment.
- ☐ You have more orders than you can take on.
- ☐ You've added a new technique or better-quality materials.
- ☐ Three months have passed since your last review.

Important

This guide helps you organize your work; it is not a promise of income. Results depend on your practice, your costs, your prices and your clients' demand.

Next step

Open the Pricing Calculator, enter the materials of the last garment you made and compare the result with what you charged.